

3D printing

Fuji film has announced a 3D Print System which will allow printing 3D images on the spot in early summer of 2010

Bio-printer

Invetech has developed the first 3D bio-printer that makes human tissues

MFD test

Nimish Sawant

nimish.sawant@thinkdigit.com

Multi-tasking has become the mantra of our life. We try to do many things simultaneously all the time. So it's only natural that we expect our digital devices to follow suit. Just like a music player is expected to play video, a cellphone expected to have a camera, why should printers stay behind.

Multi-functional devices are slowly but surely becoming an important aspect of our lives. Gone are the days when scanning and copying were things that could only be done at your local copier. Apart from printing, MFDs can scan, copy and

HOW WE TESTED

All the multifunctional devices that we got were tested on a rather basic system powered by an Intel Pentium 4 with 2 GB of RAM. We divided the MFDs into two broad categories – Monochrome Laser and Inkjet MFDs. For inkjet printers, we also tested photo quality on glossy paper.

After connecting the printers to the rig, we ran a few dry runs before actually starting off with the tests. For both the categories the common tests were carried out for text only document, mixed (text and images) document and copying a document (our magazine cover). We tested the text only document for clarity of the smallest and largest fonts, evenness of the

text at different settings. In the mixed document tests we tested the outputs against each other for clarity of text, merging colours, changing gradations of colours or white to black progression. Finally for the copy tests we compared the output to the source and checked for any flaws like noise, change in colour level, clarity. Each of the above tests was timed to see which printer gave a great output at the quickest speed. Scanning quality and speed was also tested in all the MFDs.

For inkjet printers we also did a photo print test, where we printed an A4 size photo on a glossy sheet.

We checked for the sharpness levels, colour output and also checked for flaws like merging of colours or grains in the output.

Apart from these performance tests, we gave a considerable weight to the features of all the MFDs. We also laid stress on the ease of software installation, cartridge installation, ease of connections of hardware. Also the build quality of the MFDs was given marks accordingly.

We did not perform the fax test, as this functionality was the same in all the MFDs that had them and there wasn't any variation which could allow us to do a comparison testing of this particular function.

some can even double as fax machines. With all these functionalities coming in compact form factors, you won't mind shelling out extra for a device that can take care of all your printing, scanning and copying needs.

Small office setups no

longer need to rely on external sources for their copying functions when they get themselves a compact copier which can perform printing and scanning as well. Moreover, with network connectivity in most of the devices, you have a centralised solution for all your printing and copying functions.

We got around 14 multi-functional devices to test this month which were categorised into inkjet MFDs and monochrome laser MFDs.

INKJET PRINTERS

This category of MFDs is targeted at home users

and small office setups. We got around seven MFDs in this category. All of them performed functions like printing, scanning and copying. A couple of them were even capable of performing telephone and fax functionality. While testing this category we were looking at decent text and mixed document printing and scanning functionality. We also tested these printers for photo quality as some of these MFDs are positioned as photo printers.

Features

We got around four Canon Pixma series MFDs namely MP276, MP496, MP648 and MX328. The MP series of printers have very similar designs. Each is square shaped with rounded edges having a glossy light grey finish. The MX328 is the only exception as

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Brother DCP 195C

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